an inner turmoil of anyone who creates stuff. I don't think I have adapted. It's a crisis I will have to confront very soon." It's perhaps this insecurity that compels him to create, to carry on, to get out of the bubble. With *The Horse,* he gets to do exactly that. "It's important to occupy the mainstream space," he says. Only, in Shanbag's case, the mainstream isn't just playing to the gallery, but intellectually engaging it. ■

—Suhani Singh

The Horse *will be staged at Bal Gandharva Rang Mandir, Mumbai, on Aug. 9 and 10*



STABLE CONCERNS The cast of Sunil Shanbag's production of *The Horse* in Mumbai



KBC ▶

Still Rolling

The new season of ***KAUN BANEGA CROREPATI*** is all set to premiere on August 11

When it arrived on our telescreens on July 3, 2000, *Kaun Banega Crorepati* changed the face of Indian television. Amitabh Bachchan, seemingly on the last leg of his superstardom, stormed into our homes in a brand-new avatar as a game show host, extending his career by a quarter century. Suddenly, a knowledge-based quiz show became the most watched television programme in India.

"*KBC* isn't just an entertainment show, but a show that gives Indians hope, a belief that they too can make it big in life on the basis of the knowledge and life lessons they have accrued," says Arun Sheshkumar, the show's director. "Because, unlike other reality shows, *KBC* is not casted. The contestants have to go through a rigorous competition to make it to the hot seat."

Sheshkumar has been directing each episode of *KBC* for the past 18 years. Just weeks away from its 17th season's premiere in the show's 25th year, he is busy prepping with Amitabh. Sheshkumar worked closely with the show's creator Siddhartha Basu, until he passed on the baton in the 2010s.

The machine behind *KBC* is so well-oiled that the shoot for a show due for an August 11 premiere begins on August 6. "The shooting is such that we're good to go live, but we bank episodes for up to five days before airing. On the edit table, we make the episode's flow tighter," says Sheshkumar. "Mr Bachchan is pretty much the creative director of *KBC*. He will be available with us up till November-

"MR BACHCHAN IS PRETTY MUCH THE CREATIVE DIRECTOR.... YOU WILL BE SEEING THE BEST OF 25 YEARS OF *KBC*," SAYS DIRECTOR ARUN SHESHKUMAR

December, so expect more than 100 episodes easily."

What's new? While Sheshkumar cannot divulge much, he promises, "You'll see the best of 25 years of *KBC*. All that we have learned up until now is going into this season. While we are not changing the basic format, which has become like a mantra, the packaging around it, such as the contestants' stories, will have freshness." ■

—Devarsi Ghosh